1954: a computer translated Russian. The promise: solved in 3 to 5 years.

> January 7, 1954

The machine: an IBM 701

IBM 701

Russian in

English out

> A mainframe IBM launched in 1953.

How big was the test?

60+

sentences

250 vocabulary items · 6 grammar rules

Narrow topics, carefully chosen.

1. Politics and law
2. Maths and chemistry
3. Metallurgy, communications, military affairs

Headlines worldwide. Funding followed.

> Governments invested in machine translation research.

Then the review came in.

- **1953** IBM 701 launched
- **1954** Translation demo
- **1966** ALPAC report

> ALPAC: ten years of research had failed to meet expectations.

Funding was cut dramatically.

> The 3-to-5-year promise took decades to come true.

The demo wasn't fake. It was narrow.

WHAT PEOPLE SAW

A solved problem

WHAT IT WAS

A small, controlled test

Before you buy an AI tool:

1. How many cases was it tested on?
2. Whose data?
3. Try your messiest real example